

Open City and the Bike Project



Open City Project
April 2023

[Open City](#)

Executive Summary

Introduction

The Open City project is a collaboration between the universities of Warwick, Oxford, West London, and the Open University. The project tests whether the utopian ideal of the Open City exists in real life, and explores issues of race, migration, mobility and living with diversity. The research was driven by an interest in the intersectional dynamics of mobility in the city.

Aims and process

The aim of the research was to interrogate the gendered dynamics of everyday mobility for new migrants in the city. The geographies of asylum mean that accommodation is often in lower cost, peripheral or outer ring parts of cities. This combined with transport being considered “non-essential” by the Home Office can create serious challenges for everyday mobility. There are relatively few studies on the everyday mobilities of people in the asylum system. There are even fewer that look at the gendered temporalities of care, leisure, and mobility in the asylum system. In addition, both who cycles and where cycling infrastructure is are shaped by class, race, gender, and legal status. The study therefore looks at the layered intersections of city life and city infrastructures.

Through a series of six arts workshops run by a commissioned artist with Pedal Power women across London, interviews with 9 Pedal Power women, participating observation in Pedal Power sessions and interviews with staff members and a trustee, the collaboration between Pedal Power women, the Open City team and The Bike Project produced two films that explore the (in)visibilities of cycling in the city as a woman and a migrant.



Findings

The Open City team found that those who do use their bikes after graduation from Pedal Power mainly use their bikes for leisure activities in local parks and short, often encumbered journeys to local supermarkets. Those who have tried to commute by bike have found it challenging due to the location of their accommodation and the large distances they need to cover to get to volunteering or other activities.

Barriers to cycling included

- Bikes getting stolen / Nowhere safe to lock bikes in asylum accommodation
- Being moved or re-dispersed and having to leave bikes behind
- Having to store bicycles by beds or on sofas

Benefits of having a bike

- Improved wellbeing through leisure cycling / Opportunities for exercise
- Being able to explore new neighbourhoods
- Having ownership over a physical object and the materiality of the bike

Benefits of participating in Pedal Power

- Developing new networks
- Gaining new skills through continued involvement in TBP (mechanic classes)
- Accessing new opportunities for volunteering and onward referrals
- Ongoing social support from Bike Buddies and Pedal Power instructors

Recommendations for The Bike Project

- Many participants had to leave their bikes behind when they were re-dispersed or made to move on in their asylum journey. Creating a secure cycle drop off or storage scheme for bike recipients could allow people who are re-dispersed continued access to cycling.
- Many participants did not have secure bike storage where they are accommodated. The Bike Project could campaign for more accessible and widespread secure hangar schemes.
- Some participants did not keep cycling even though they intended to. For this reason, a confidence check in 3-6 months after graduating from Pedal Power could be useful.
- Some Pedal Power women have young children with whom they cycle in the park. For this reason, cycle training specific to cycling with young children could be useful.
- Social activities were central to building confidence and Pedal Power participants would appreciate more social activities if possible.

The above could be supported with existing campaigning efforts to provide greater cycle infrastructure such as racks, lanes, and secure hangars across the city beyond arterial routes into the centre.

Conclusion

It is clear that The Bike Project provide an indispensable tool for empowerment and access to the city. Receiving a bike has clear wellbeing benefits to the women who participate in Pedal Power, however, if cycling is to become a sustainable and viable way for women in the asylum system to survive the challenges of the asylum system, then there is a need for more ongoing points of connection and sustained contact with graduates.

The Open City team, April 2023

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Introduction

Background

The Open City project is a collaboration between the universities of Warwick, Oxford, West London, and the Open University. The three-year project, funded by the Economic and Social Research Council, looks at the social and political life of the city to test whether the utopian ideal of the Open City exists in real life, and explore issues of race, migration, mobility and living with diversity. It explores how the city accommodates new forms of urban life, through the social configuration of its spaces and places, and looks at the ways urban government at the city-wide and borough scales reflect, promote, or limit the idea of the Open City. The project focuses on the dynamics of London life using archival research to explore histories and patterns of welcome and migration in the city; large data-sets to uncover residential churn and mobility in the city; ethnographic research to engage with how people's geographic relationships shape their experience of the city; and interviews to explore how the city is claimed and the idea of an open, welcoming city is promoted. The project does this at different scales. On housing estates, at the borough level and the city level.

As a part of this, the team are interested in how new arrivals in the city get around, come to know the city, and mentally and experientially map it. We are particularly interested in the intersectional dynamics of mobility in the city. We therefore explore how the intersectional dynamics of race, legal status, and gender layer and intersect with transport inequalities, everyday mobility, and urban planning.

The Open City team are delighted that The Bike Project has welcomed them into Pedal Power and the wider organisation to conduct and co-produce research. The collaboration with The Bike Project aims to: contribute to The Bike Project's impact work, produce data that can be used by The Bike Project in funding applications, deliver arts workshops with Pedal Power participants, foster new connections among Pedal Power participants and produce research data for publication and impact work by the Open City team.

This report provides information about the research context, process and findings from our work, including short- and longer-term outcomes for Pedal Power participants. It also makes some key recommendations on promoting continued bike use by Pedal Power women with likely implications for the wider Bike Project client group.



Context

The need for research

The research layers three overlapping fields of enquiry:

- Everyday life and mobility in the asylum system
- Who cycles and cycling identities
- Mobility and cycling infrastructure in the city



Everyday life and mobility in the asylum system

The UK Immigration and Asylum Act 1999 makes provisions about immigration and asylum; determining leave to enter, support given to people seeking asylum, detention, bail conditions and rights of appeal. Section 95 of the Act introduced compulsory dispersal, which provides usually shared accommodation and compulsorily moves people seeking asylum to different parts of Britain – usually post-industrial urban areas. Section 95 also introduced weekly support payments to meet the essential needs of people seeking asylum but did not consider transport or communication to be “essential”. Weekly asylum support payments in 2022 were £40.85 for each adult recipient, or 58% of the definition of destitution.

In London a single hopper fare on the bus costs £1.65 and a single off-peak tube journey can cost between £1.80 and £4.80. In other cities where The Bike Project works, single bus fares can cost around £3. The prohibitive cost of public transport because of punitive asylum support payments combined with the peripheral location of asylum accommodation can exclude people from physical spaces in the city. This has significant implications for being able to access voluntary sector organisations, maintain social connections, meet basic needs, and access statutory services where eligible.

There are relatively few studies on the everyday mobilities of people in the asylum system. There are even fewer that look at the gendered temporalities of care, leisure, and mobility in the asylum system. In addition, both who cycles and where cycling infrastructure is are shaped by class, race, gender, and legal status. The study therefore looks at the layered intersections of city life and city infrastructures.

Cycling identities

In 2021, men in England were three times more likely than women to cycle (including leisure cycling) and women in England cycled on average 23 miles across the year in comparison to 89 miles cycled by men. Women cyclists tend to make shorter, more encumbered journeys on orbital routes – often to carry out care or other socially reproductive responsibilities.

Moreover, cycling in the city is often associated with MAMILs or “middle aged men in lycra”. There are strong associations between cycling as a classed and gendered choice available to those who can afford to switch between modes of transport and prioritise environmental factors in making decisions about their everyday mobilities. This also has a strong relationship to the embodied nature of cycling with cycling mobilities associated with ‘fit’ bodies.

In addition, who cycles is highly racialised. Only 14% of London’s cyclists are from racialised minorities. Underrepresented in this, however, are cycle couriers who are often men from racialised minorities. Although hyper visible through branding and uniform, cycle couriers are often ‘invisible’ road users – attracting very little attention except for when described as “dangerous” or “bad” cyclists. This introduces a binary between ‘good’ cyclists who choose to cycle for health and environmental reasons and ‘bad’ cyclists who disobey the rules of the road. These intersections of class, race and gender also highlight wider issues around having the freedom to choose one’s mode of transport, the cost of transport in the city, and the global legacies of private motorised transport being both aspirational and idealised.¹

Like the work carried out by Pedal Power, there are other cycle training initiatives for migrant women both in the UK and abroad. However, unlike Pedal Power, many of these are framed in terms of “overcoming” or “emancipating” women from cultural barriers to cycling. Unlike The Bike Project, few of these initiatives focus on the necessities of getting around, coming to know a new city or the prohibitive cost of public transport. How Pedal Power women and The Bike Project users more generally use their bikes, however, is shaped by the physicalities of the city.

¹ Lam, T.F. (2018). Hackney: a cycling borough for whom? *Applied Mobilities*, 3(2), 115-132. <https://doi.org/10.1080/23800127.2017.1305151>



Map showing multiple locations where project participants are living or have lived during their time in London

Cycling in the city

In London, cycling infrastructure is arterial. The Cycle Super Highways mostly connect areas in zone 2 (and sometimes 3) to city centre destinations. In this way, London's cycle infrastructure targets MAMILs who may use their bikes to commute to work. This shows that where cycle infrastructure is placed and who it serves is not value neutral. This is also evident in the location of bike racks. Bike racks are most often placed on main roads and not on quieter side roads generally preferred by women cyclists. This in turn intersects with the availability of secure cycle hangars. Not only are these predominantly available in inner London boroughs, but they also require a) a bank account, b) proof address, and c) digital literacy to register in addition to long waiting lists. These dynamics can exclude people with precarious housing or immigration statuses meaning that those who need secure cycle storage the most are unable to access it. Finally, the majority of S95 dispersal accommodation in London is in outer boroughs such as: Hillingdon, Hounslow, Barking and Dagenham and Redbridge.² These boroughs are not only more likely to be dominated by dual carriageways and the ring road, but they are also less served by cycle infrastructure. This combined with existing inequalities in these boroughs and travelling long distances by bus to access support, services and social networks can exacerbate the challenges of living on asylum support or being undocumented in the city.

The dynamics described above have driven the Open City team's engagement with Pedal Power and in part structure some of the findings and recommendations below. The following section describes how we worked with Pedal Power and the process that informed the research.

² Newell, B. (2022). Asylum and protection – asylum seekers in receipt of support by local authority. Immigration system statistics. Home Office and Office for National Statistics. Retrieved from: <https://www.gov.uk/government/statistical-data-sets/asylum-and-resettlement-datasets> 19th April 2023.

Approach and process

The Open City team worked with artist, Natasha Davis, who was commissioned through a competitive tender run by Counterpoints Arts, to co-produce two films with Pedal Power women. The core film theme is the (in)visibilities of cycling in the city as a woman and a migrant.

The Open City team began with discussions with former CEO Jem Stein who highlighted the need for more qualitative data on gender and the work of Pedal Power. Before designing the research, the Open City team conducted interviews with trustees and former staff members to ensure that the design was led by need and was sensitive to the client group. Through further discussions with The Bike Project staff members we agreed to:

- Run arts-based workshops with Pedal Power women
- Interview Pedal Power women who took part in the workshops
- Participate and observe Pedal Power sessions
- Participate in Bike Buddy training

Pedal Power women were recruited through the Pedal Power manager and were invited to participate in a launch workshop by Natasha Davis. The initial workshop explored the art forms the women were interested in. When it became clear that there was a common interest in textiles including dress making and embroidery, Natasha designed the workshop programme based on these interests.

The workshops brought Pedal Power women from across the city together in their home boroughs to share local knowledge and experience while filming and creating art in different city parks in the summer of 2022. The workshop locations included Kew Gardens, Victoria Park, Greenwich Park, and the Deptford Bike Project workshop. Early art forms and languages included: movement, mime and found object sculpture. This led to a desire to produce a dress that women could wear while cycling to draw attention to themselves, assert visibility and occupy road space. The workshop at the Deptford Bike Project therefore involved a skill sharing and sewing session that led to the creation of two dresses made to resemble formal Kurdish dress with long trains that would billow out behind the wearer. During the following art workshop, participants embroidered a map of London highlighting their home boroughs on the train of the dress. Filming and interviews conducted during the workshops fed into the two films.

Following this, individual interviews with Pedal Power women explored their early experiences in London, their everyday mobilities and experiences of cycling in the city. The collaboration culminated in a film screening at The Bike Project shop in October 2022.



Findings

The Open City team found that those who do use their bikes after graduation from Pedal Power mainly use their bikes for leisure activities in local parks and short, often encumbered journeys to local supermarkets. Those who have tried to commute by bike have found it challenging due to the location of their accommodation and the large distances they need to cover to get to volunteering or other activities. The following sections consider the short-term impacts of participating in Pedal Power, women's longer term outcomes, and some of the intersections between city infrastructures and living on asylum support.



Women's experience of The Bike Project: short term outcomes

"I feel like I'm a queen"

The physicality of participating in Pedal Power increased fitness and wellbeing in the short term. It also brought participants into contact with other women living in their local area who are also service users.

"I sweat, I feel good in myself"

The speed with which bikes were delivered following referral was also remarked upon as something that made women feel supported and valued and was contrasted with the state of limbo and chronic waiting in the asylum system:

"They delivered it in something like three weeks. They delivered it right to my door – it was great. All I had to do was walk downstairs and open the door, it was super simple and they gave me a package with all the bike accessories I could need and I have to say I found this really moving, they'd really thought deeply and considered everything. It was very thoughtful."

Despite this, two women commented that they found the referral pathways challenging. One had reached out to The Bike Project directly but did not receive a response, eventually having to become involved in Refugee Council activities in order to receive a referral and another would have preferred to self-refer and did not stay involved with the referral partner once she had received her bike.

In addition, the women who took part after the easing of lockdown restrictions noted the challenge of travelling to Dalston for the training sessions and one remarked that it would be better if more sessions could be run in different parts of the city. One woman remarked that if it hadn't been for additional encouragement from The Bike Project staff, she would not have travelled to the Pedal Power sessions.

With respect to the bikes themselves, two of the women who took part first received bikes that were too big for them – something that they found off putting. Similarly, at Pedal Power sessions depending on turn out, there wasn't always enough bikes in the right size for participants.

The difference a bike makes: longer term outcomes

The quotes below powerfully illustrate the impact that receiving a bike has had on Pedal Power participants' sense of self. It is clear that involvement in Pedal Power increased women's self-confidence, enabled them to develop new social networks and provided ways for them to use their time while waiting for an outcome on their asylum claim.

"Cycling was one of my childhood dreams. It was from that time because in my country women weren't allowed to do that, but I never forgot my dream. When I came to this country and I saw the people, especially women and girls riding the bike I thought "wow so lucky" and then I had this opportunity when I learn how to ride and now, I ride the bike in the place where I live, to go to the supermarket, to the park. Every time when I ride the bike, I think "thank you so much Bike Project" really I feel very very confident and very very independent because of the Bike Project".

"So it's really not just about donating bikes, it's more holistic. They don't stop at the bike. This actually gave me a sense of... a sense of connection. I felt connected. I felt connected to the bike project. As a charity they don't just give the bike and leave, they give you a sense of connection and they build connections between users and between users and their volunteers. Like, thanks to that, I met people, I developed a Bike Project network."

"Pedal Power now is my life"

At least four participants highlighted the significant relationships they had built with Pedal Power instructors. Instructors maintained relationships with Pedal Power graduates. One instructor was described as a “lollypop” and all were spoken about with high praise. The Open City team note from their time spent at Pedal Power sessions, however, that instructor turnover is high and employment practices precarious. This may lead to inconsistency and higher dropout rates for current and future Pedal Power participants.

For those with children or family members in the UK, receiving a bike also enabled families to develop and maintain stronger ties to each other. One woman remarked that she now takes her children cycling in the local park while another said that she and her brother often go out cycling together.

“My bike is my friend, it’s my support animal”

Common across most participants was the value of the bike as an object. The permanence and physicality of the bike in the face of the repeat ruptures, uncertainty and precarity of the asylum process had huge significance. Even for those who did not continue to use their bikes after graduating from Pedal Power, the sense of ownership over and materiality of the bike had a powerful impact on how women felt about their relationship with The Bike Project. When dispersed in the asylum system, or re-dispersed, people are only allowed two bags of personal possessions. Receiving a bike therefore, lends a sense of permanence and provides a concrete, large object to own and maintain.

This, however, also comes with challenges. When re-dispersed or when their legal status changes, two women had to leave their bikes behind. One left her bike with a friend and was not able to return to collect it and transport it across London by train for three months. The other who had previously been dispersed to Cardiff had to seek out a new bike when she arrived in London.





Women's mobility and bike use

The Open City team were surprised that not all the women we worked with continue to use their bicycles for everyday mobility after graduating from Pedal Power. Most of the cycle journeys the 9 Pedal Power graduates we worked with make are short leisure trips in local parks, or short encumbered journeys to supermarkets or occasionally, doctor's surgeries.

"When I go to some close spaces like Lidl for small shopping I ride, I use my bike"

"One mile, two miles enough for my bike. For shopping, for GP appointments and for mental good feeling and freshness. Every time I go for new route. Sometimes I am talking to myself you are crazy why are you going strange routes but then I say to myself no find this world, find this world with bike but when you feel tiredness, go home."

For those participants who continued cycling after graduating, most used their bikes in their immediate local area. Two made longer journeys when accompanied by others or by a Bike Buddy whereas another struggled to make the long commute from her accommodation in Croydon to her college in Brixton. One participant said that she used her bike to discover her new neighbourhood and as a way to "escape" from her shared accommodation during the pandemic.

Barriers and challenges in the city

Most women who took part in the research live in outer-ring London boroughs. For one participant who lives in Gants Hill and does not cycle despite having built her own bike, local infrastructure presents a major challenge as the area lacks cycle paths, is car dominated and shaped by busy A-Roads, a motorway, and the ring road. In addition, meeting everyday needs often requires travelling long distances. For example, the participant who lives in Gants Hill must travel to Victoria Coach station every other week and travels to The Bike Project workshop in Deptford once a week – distances too far to travel by bike. The geography of asylum and the geographies of London therefore present a challenge to cycling as an everyday mobility tool.

The long distances travelled by the women the Open City team worked with also meant very careful accounting in everyday life. For one participant, the local food bank where she lives in Bexley is too far away for her to travel to by bike. However, as the return bus journey costs £3.30, travelling to the food bank is only cost effective if she receives a food package worth £15 or travels to the food bank on days where she is given an Oyster Card top up so that she can travel by bus to Deptford to volunteer at The Bike Project. In this way, the women the Open City team worked with are both hyper mobile and immobilised by their legal status and the geographical and infrastructural realities of the city.

As is evident below, secure cycle storage was a challenge for many participants:

“No place to put it in the flat or outside, there is not garage, no covered bike place. Also the stairs are a problem, the lift is never working and the bike is hard to fit, my son is not always there to carry bike down the stairs. There is no bike parking, and people might steal bike. So the bike is on the sofa.”

“Where I lock my bike outside is plastic pipe, you could just cut it. We have nothing you know iron or something to lock it. No rod. So god is looking after my bike but at least now I have one space in the bathroom.”

Without secure, covered, outdoor cycle storage, most participants kept their bikes in their rooms – often up steep flights of stairs. One participant keeps her bike by her bed, whereas another keeps hers on her sofa. For women who live in shared asylum accommodation, hallways are often taken up by prams and pushchairs meaning that they must rely on “god” to “look after” their bikes. The poor conditions in S95 accommodation and in hotels means that access to secure cycle storage is almost impossible. In addition, for those who are made to share rooms, keeping bikes indoors also presents a significant challenge.

“Not having a bike felt like a lack – it was like an emptiness, something was missing.”

Closely linked to this is women’s experiences of their bikes being stolen. A third of the women the Open City team worked with reported having their bikes stolen. One participant had her bike stolen despite using a flex cable and a D-lock in the parking area of her block of flats. The women who had bikes stolen commented on the speed with which The Bike Project were able to provide replacements and were pleased with the support they received.

Recommendations

Given the current policy environment there are clearly challenges with respect to advocating for even small changes such as lobbying the Home Office to ensure that private providers of asylum accommodation provide bike racks or similar means of securely storing a bike, or to insist that S95 support is changed to reflect that transport and communication are essential needs. However, based on Open City's findings above, there are some ways in which The Bike Project could provide additional support to bike recipients.

The first of these is creating a possible bike hub or medium-term storage service for people who are re-dispersed or whose legal statuses change. This could involve recipients asking for their bikes to be collected (or dropping their bikes off at a designated local hub) in the case of being made to move and being able to collect or ask for their bike (or indeed a similar bike) to be delivered or collected at their accommodation. This could also be applicable for people who enter the 28 day move on period or are refused asylum and are homeless or in a position where they may have to sofa surf.

Second, broader campaigning could involve calling on local authorities to provide more equitable access to secure on street cycle hangars that are accessible to all. Campaigns calling for cycle lanes in outer ring boroughs could also be effective while also providing people in the asylum system with greater opportunities for cycle-based mobility.

Third, for those with young children, The Bike Project may wish to consider family-oriented cycle training with a focus on safe cycling with children to promote whole family cycling. This could be especially relevant where The Bike Project gives bikes to the children of Pedal Power participants.

Fourth, for those women who decide against cycling after completing the Pedal Power course, it may be worth considering offering check-ins at 3, 6, or 9 months to see if Pedal Power graduates require additional support. This could potentially be accompanied with refresher courses if desired.

Finally, if resource allows, it may be worth exploring the possibility of providing greater job security to Pedal Power instructors to ensure consistency for participants. This could also be accompanied with returning to a model of provision that takes place across the city.



Outcomes and conclusion

The Open City team will build on this report through the publication of journal articles to share the work of The Bike Project and the findings presented here to academic audiences. In addition, the Open City project will share some of the findings above at academic conferences and with colleagues in both the third and public sectors to amplify the work The Bike Project is doing and draw attention to the way different interested stakeholders can work together to bring about change. The Open City team have so far presented the findings above to colleagues at Sustrans and the Women of Colour Cycling Collective and look forward to the opportunity to disseminate the collaboration more widely. The Open City team will continue to promote the above on its website and social media channels.

The Bike Project provides an indispensable tool for empowerment and access to the city. Receiving a bike has clear wellbeing benefits to the women who participate in Pedal Power. However, if cycling is to become a sustainable and viable way for women in the asylum system to survive the challenges of the asylum system, then there is a need for more ongoing points of connection and sustained contact with graduates, as well as support to overcome the challenges of secure cycle storage and precarious housing.

The Open City team would like to thank Natasha Davis, with special thanks to The Bike Project for their support and particularly to all the Pedal Power women who took part in the workshops and research, to Kessem Adiv and Anya Jhoti for their ongoing support throughout the collaboration. The Open City team would like to thank Pedal Power instructors for their welcome to training sessions.

The full film and film trailer may be viewed at:

<https://opencitywarwick.co.uk/home-2/collaborations/cycling-visibility/>

The Open City team April 2023

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